Wind in the Sails

Who was VOC? And how did a small-town pleader launch the audacious project of promoting a multi-lakh shipping enterprise?

V.O. Chidambaram Pillai was born on 5 September 1872 in Ottapidaram, the taluk headquarters of the same name—Ottapidaram was one of the ten taluks of Tirunelveli district—with a population of barely 4,000. Panchalamkurichi, the headquarters of the Palayakkarar chieftain Veerapandiya Kattabomman who had valiantly fought the British and was martyred in 1799, was 3 km to the north, and VOC took great pride in this geographic proximity. He was a Saiva Vellalar, a landholding caste ranking next only to Brahmins in hierarchy and boasting of considerable cultural capital. His father Olaganatha Pillai was a pleader himself, who also held briefs for the adjoining *zamin* of Ettayapuram. The family was prosperous with considerable land and other assets.

What we know of VOC's early education comes from his autobiography. After a traditional education in Ottapidaram, he was sent to Tuticorin at the age of fourteen. His academic career was nothing to speak of, as he alternated between St Xavier's High School and Caldwell High School before studying briefly at the Hindu College, Tirunelveli. He matriculated, not without some effort, and, for some time, worked as a clerk in the taluk office. All was not well between father and son. The reasons are not specified by VOC but evidently Olaganatha Pillai was not happy with the way Chidambaram was shaping. Once, after a particularly furious thrashing at his father's hands, VOC ran away to Madurai, donning the garb of a *sanyasi*. But he calmed down soon, and his life took a new path. At his father's behest, he went to Tiruchirappalli where he studied law privately. In 1895, he sat for the pleader-ship examination and qualified as a second-grade pleader at the relatively older age of twenty-three. After receiving the *sanad*, he appeared in the district munsiff's court at Ottapidaram, and his practice flourished. He was soon married to Valliammai. Acting as his moral compass, Valliammai played a big role in laying the foundation of his transformation into a public figure. Initially, VOC seems to have been the